

Three sessions, one loop

Everything from the week in one place: the arc, the moves, the five framework trees, the sizing recipe — and the three cases you ran. Keep it next to your practice.

01 The arc of every case

It starts with **the prompt** — they read you a business problem, out loud. Everything that follows answers it.

MOVE	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT PROVES
0 • Play it back	Your own words — situation, goal, ask. Numbers locked in. Ends with “did I get that right?”	You listened — and you bought ten seconds to think
1 • Clarify	The three musts: how the business works (only when it isn’t obvious), the objective, the scope	Judgment — you find the target before you run
2 • Structure	A big question broken into smaller, checkable ones. MECE: no overlaps, no gaps	Organized thinking — the most heavily graded moment
3 • Analyze	You ask for data; they hand you tables, charts, numbers. Shape → story → so-what	Comfort with numbers under pressure
4 • Recommend	Recap their question → answer it → justification → risks → next steps	You can commit with imperfect information

Always in your head: the question · your best guess (the hypothesis) · so what? These three run on a loop in a great candidate’s head, the entire case.

02 How you shine

GIVE THE SO WHAT

Every number gets a verdict. “Sixty million pairs — that’s a big market.” A fact you don’t interpret is a fact you wasted.

TIE IT BACK

“...though we’d need a big share of that to hit the target.” Every dot connects back to the question they actually asked.

STAY HYPOTHESIS-DRIVEN

Guess the answer early, then spend the case proving or killing that guess — it picks what you check first and what data you ask for. A doctor doesn’t run every test; she guesses the diagnosis and tests for THAT. On yes/no questions, the guess becomes the tree.

COMMUNICATION IS THE JOB — answer first · clear and concise · think out loud · stay human. They’re deciding one thing: would I put this person in front of a client?

03 Clarifying questions: dos and don’ts

Two or three questions covers it. Aim them at the three musts:

THE MUST	THE QUESTION, WORD FOR WORD	WHY IT MATTERS
1 • How the business works	“How does this business make money?”	Only when it isn’t obvious — a salad bar sells salads. Save it for the murky models.
2 • The objective	“What does success look like — how much, by when?”	No target means you can’t judge any answer.
3 • The scope	“Are we looking at the whole business, or one part?”	Half the tree gets pruned before you draw it.
Bonus • Context	“What’s changed in the past year — inside or outside?”	Often hands you the clue. It cracked Marble’s open.

The traps — each one has a better question hiding behind it:

TRAP	SOUNDS LIKE	ASK INSTEAD
✗ Asking to sound smart (vanity)	“What’s their EBITDA margin?”	“How does the business make money?”
✗ Not enough questions	Going straight to your structure	“What does success look like — how much, by when?”
✗ Too deep	“How many items on the menu?”	“Is it the whole business, or one part?”
✗ An answer in disguise	“Have they tried raising prices?”	“What’s changed in the past year?”

The filter, always: **“will the answer change how I structure?”** If no — skip it.

04 Structures: start big, break it down

A structure is a **big question, broken into smaller questions you can actually answer**. That’s it. “Why are CityGym’s memberships down 20%?” is too big to answer in one go — so you don’t try. “Are fewer new members joining? Are more current members leaving? Is it every gym, or just some?” — each of those, you can check. Answer the small ones and the big one answers itself.

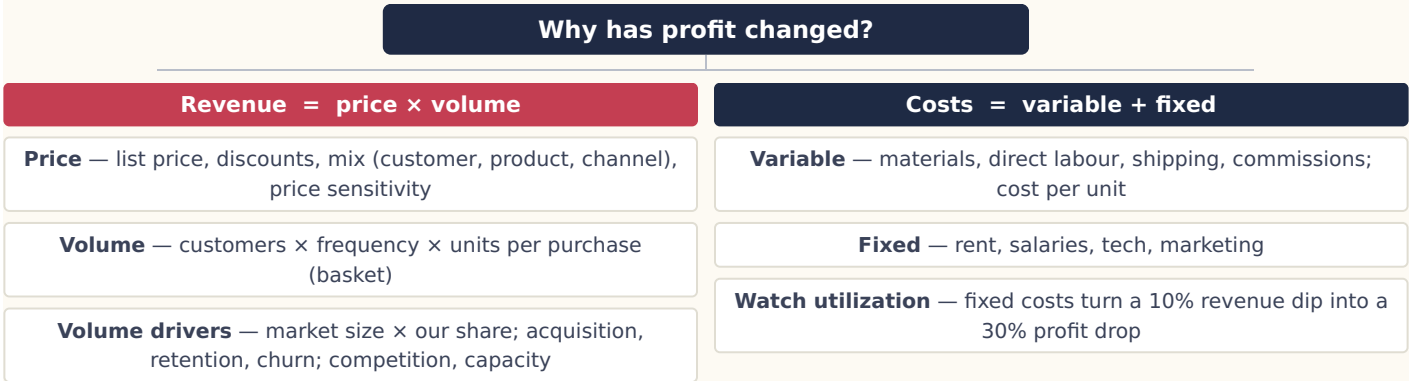
FOUR STEPS, SAME EVERY TIME	HOW IT SOUNDS
1 • Start from their exact question	Write it at the top of your page — everything hangs off it.
2 • Split it into smaller questions	Profit down means revenue fell or costs rose — there’s no third option.
3 • Check it’s MECE	No overlaps (nothing counted twice), no gaps (nothing hiding). Build from a formula or a process — it’s MECE almost for free.
4 • Say it out loud, pick a lane	Walk them through why the branches answer the question — then use your guess: “I’d start revenue-side, because...”

Tailoring: use their nouns — cups, walkers, memberships. If a branch could fit any company, it isn’t tailored yet. Rename it until it couldn’t.

05 The five framework trees

Real cases blend these — knowing them cold helps enormously; applying them blindly is the trap. Tailor the labels and the leaves to THIS client, every time.

1 • Profitability — “why has profit changed, and what should we do?”

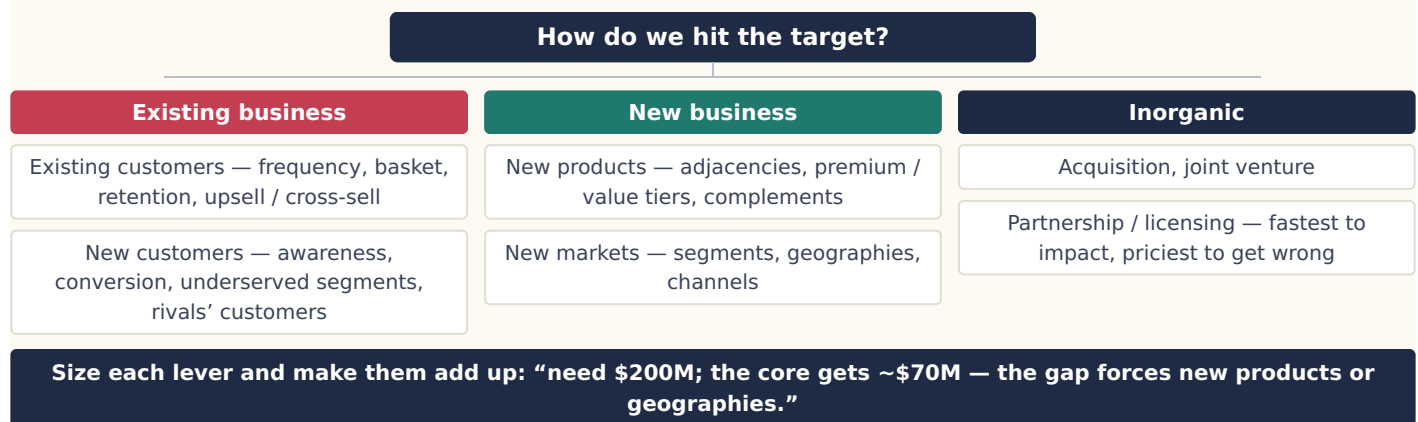


Diagnose before prescribing: quantify the decline → revenue or costs → isolate the driver → find WHY it moved → targeted fix.

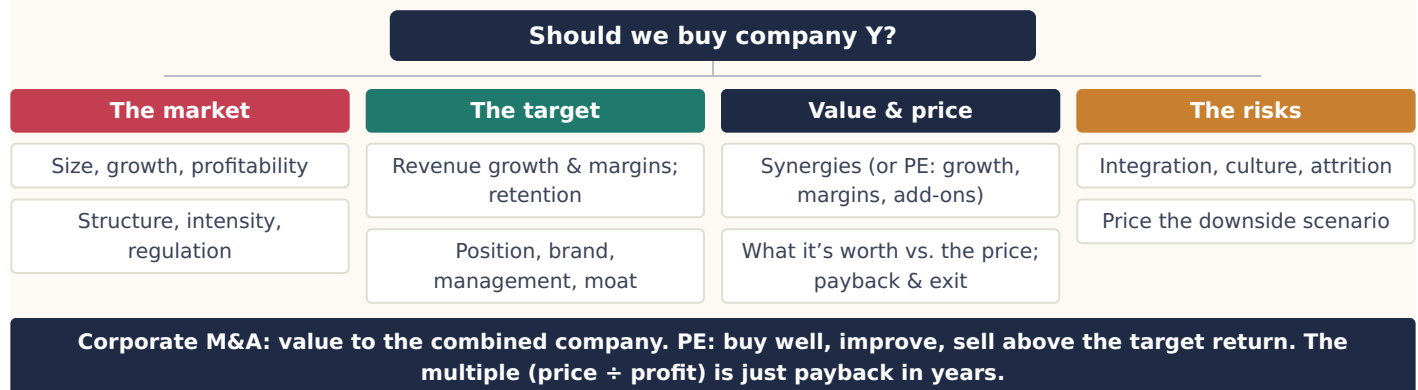
2 • Market entry / product launch — “should we enter — and if so, how?”



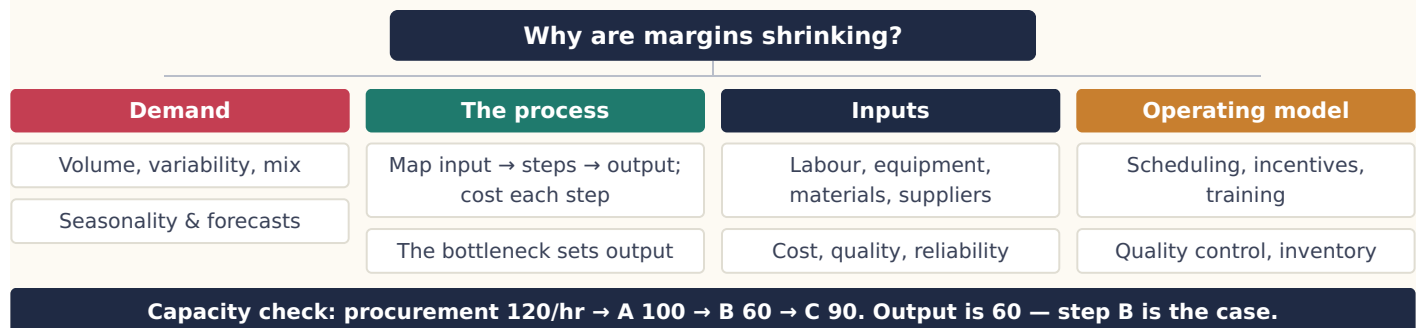
3 • Growth — “how do we hit the target?” Define metric, amount, timeline first.



4 • M&A / investment / private equity — “should we buy — and at what price?”



5 • Operations — “what's causing the problem?” Pin the KPI first, then map THEIR process.



Stuck? Two backup splits — *always MECE by definition; your second layer earns the credit.*



They also nest inside bigger trees — **Java House's traffic branch split internal vs. external.**

PESTLE — the “what else could matter?” scan: politics · economy · society · technology · legal · environment. Run it silently, twenty seconds; say only the ones that bite. A scan finds risks; a speech loses the room.

06 Market sizing, the recipe

Four steps, every time: write the equation → make assumptions (round, defensible, said out loud) → check them (offer a range on the shaky one) → do the math. The goal is a **defensible** number, not a precise one. Building the equation: who's the buyer — people, households, businesses? Start with everyone and cut. Split segments that behave differently. Then frequency, then price.

COUNTRY	PEOPLE	HOUSEHOLDS	AGE
United States	~340M	~130M	38
China	~1.4B	~500M	40
India	~1.45B	~300M	28
Japan	~125M	~55M	49
Brazil	~215M	~75M	34
Canada / UK	40M / 70M	16M / 28M	~40

The week's sizings:

- Coffee in the building ≈ 800 cups a weekday — pin the metric first (bought ≠ drunk).
- US sneakers ≈ \$28B — kids buy 2 pairs, adults 1; segments do the work.
- TVs in Canada ≈ 4M a year — the buyer is the household; owning ≠ buying.
- Toronto bubble tea ≈ \$175M — 500K drinkers × \$7 × 50 weeks.
- GTA dog care ≈ \$250M — daycare regulars + boarding-only, priced separately.

07 The three cases you ran

CASE	TYPE	WHAT HAPPENED
Java House Session 1	Profitability	Maria's five coffee shops, profit \$400K → \$280K. The tree found it: traffic at the flagship, lost to a new Starbucks — basket held at \$5. The bridge closed: revenue −\$180K, costs −\$60K, profit −\$120K. Call: defend the flagship — loyalty push, local offerings Starbucks can't copy.
Boba Bar Session 2	Market entry	Dev's twelve Vancouver shops, \$1.5M saved, Toronto on his mind. Sized the market at ~\$175M; nobody owns a tenth of it; one shop clears \$150K at full pace; the two-year payback rides on the ramp. Call: enter — three corporate shops near the queues, prove 200 cups a day.
Marble's Play & Stay Session 3	M&A / PE	Fetch Capital offered twelve dog daycare sites for \$24M, profit flat at \$3M. The market checked out (~\$250M, growing); the exhibit showed three vintages — the original four full, 900 dogs waitlisted. The original four show what every site becomes: \$0.45M each → ~\$5M chain-wide → payback inside five years. Call: buy — tight, but it clears.

Plus the cold reps: Seoul Fried Chicken (entry, run on two cities) · PaddlePro (a PE deal at 10× profit — the growth question IS the case) · Tondo Gelato (growth — make the levers add up to +\$60M).

08 The five habits that read as advanced

Lead the room — close branches out loud, announce the next one, ask for exactly what you need. **Quantify everything** — numbers end debates; adjectives start them. **Think one step ahead** — every move causes the next

thing; price it before they ask. **Pre-empt the risk** — name what would change your mind, unprompted. **Synthesize, don't summarize** — one argument that happens to have evidence, never a list of findings.

From here: one or two live cases a week · build a case group · debrief in writing · read how industries make money · size things for fun. By recruiting season, playback-guess-structure-so-what is just how you think.

Questions any time: caley@valence.co · The Offer Lab — and for reps between now and interviews, The Offer Lab + Casey AI is there 24/7.